Find the Hacker: Game Guide

Game description

Find the Hacker is a team-based coding challenge where two teams compete in a timed match. One team's **Coder** writes a solution to the assigned programming problem. The other team's **hackers** try to disrupt that solution using a limited set of built in code changes. The Coder must keep the program correct, pass the public tests, and submit it for final testing before time runs out.

The game comines programming, code review, teamwork, and time management. The application keeps the match timer, code changes, attack limits, submissions, and results on the server.

Teams and roles

Teams register with **three to four participants**. The captain enters the team roster and gets a four-digit team code. Teammates join using that code and the email address entered for them, then create their own account password.

When teams are complete and paired, one team plays as the **Coder team** and the other as the **Hacker team**. The organizer assigns the challenge and controls when the match starts. The roles apply to the team: teammates should coordinate their work and communicate through their event setup.

The Coder's role

The Coder team is responsible for solving the assigned challenge during the match.

1. Read the problem statement, input/output format, constraints, and examples.
2. Write or update the solution in the match editor using the supported language.
3. Coordinate changes with teammates and keep an eye on the shared live code.
4. Run the solution against the **public test cases** to find errors.
5. Fix errors introduced by the team or by Detective attacks.
6. Submit the exact version of the code that passed all public tests.

The website only enables submission after the current code passes every public test. A submission is then checked by the server against the challenge's tests, including hidden cases. An accepted submission wins the match for the Coder team and ends the timer. If the match ends without an accepted solution, the match is resolved by the configured rules or organizer action.

The Hackers role

The Hackers team examines the Coder's shared solution and uses the game's **allowlisted attacks** to introduce controlled changes. Attacks are subject to a token limit, a time window, and a seven second cooldown. They are available only while the match is active and the attack window remains open.

Current attack windows and token budgets are:

Difficulty	Match time	Attack window	Attack tokens
Easy	3 minutes	2 minutes 10 seconds	8
Medium	5 minutes	3 minutes 30 seconds	12
Hard	8 minutes	5 minutes 36 seconds	15

The available attack types include changing a condition or operator, changing a logical operator or loop boundary, altering brackets, misspelling a supported code token, removing a statement-ending semicolon, changing an increment/decrement, and changing a zero comparison. An attack may fail to apply if the code does not contain a supported target. The application records attack outcomes.

Hackers should use attacks strategically: look for code that is vulnerable to a small change, watch how the Coder responds, and avoid spending tokens when no valid target is present. The goal is to challenge the opposing team within the game rules, not to access accounts, infrastructure, or anything outside the match.

How to participate professionally

Before the event

- Register with accurate names and email addresses.
- The captain should share the four digit team code only with the listed teammates.
- Each participant should join using their own roster email and account.
- Read the organizer's rules for match order, scoring, communication, and tie handling.

Confirm that you can sign in and that your team appears in the event.

- Agree on a team communication method and divide responsibilities before the match.

During a match

- Join with your own account; online status reflects each participant's live website connection.
- Follow the assigned role. Only the Coder team edits and submits the solution; only the Detective team can use attacks.
- Keep discussion focused and professional. Do not share credentials or attempt to interfere with the service.
- Coder teammates should review the problem and test feedback together. Hacker should coordinate their limited attacks.
- Use the server timer as the source of truth. Disconnecting does not stop the match clock.
- Report technical issues to the organizer promptly and include any displayed request ID. Do not repeatedly submit or attack while a request is still processing.